

Rhodes Landfall

Rob's track: the long scripts

Wednesday 30 September 2026 · Scarlet Lady · alongside 09:00, sails
18:00

01 • Landfall

Cruise berth, Tourist Port (Akti Sachtouri)

Welcome to Rhodes. Before you walk, stand still for a moment at the bottom of the gangway and look west, toward the wall. For three thousand years people have arrived on this shore the way you just did, from the water, looking at the town. The Greeks came first, in three cities, then one. The Romans came here to learn how to speak. Then Byzantines, Crusaders, Ottomans, and Italians, and now you, off a ship the size of a small town. Some came to trade, some came to take it, and some came because they had nowhere else to go.

The harbour you are standing in has a name for that. In the year three hundred and five before Christ, a Macedonian prince called Demetrius, later nicknamed the Besieger, sailed into this bay with two hundred warships and more than a hundred and seventy transports, forty thousand men, and behind them almost a thousand private ships full of traders hoping to pick over the wreckage. He floated a boom of spiked logs across the entrance. The Rhodians answered with fire ships packed with pitch. You will hear how that ended later, at the harbour mouth, because the ending is a thirty-three metre bronze statue of the sun.

The city in front of you was designed around one certainty, that someone was always coming. Everything you will see today, the moat, the bastions, the gates, the round towers, is an answer to that. It is also a city nobody ever abandoned. Everyone who took it kept using it, so this is a stack of centuries rather than a museum of one moment, and today we walk down through them and back up again.

The nearest gate is to your right, about five minutes along the quay, a wide opening in the sea wall called the Gate of the Virgin. Walk toward the wall, keep the sea on your left, and do not go through yet. The next track starts at the gate.

One practical note. Another ship arrived at seven this morning, so the Palace and the museum will be busiest from mid-morning. We go there first. Lunch is booked for later. Your ship sails at six, and sunset is at

six fifty-four, which means the best light of the day will be from the top deck, with this wall sliding astern. Nobody has to hurry back for it.

02 • The Threshold

Gate of the Virgin (Pyli Panagias)

Stop before the arch. Do not go through yet.

Turn around and look at where you came from, your ship filling the harbour, the water, the quay you just walked, and, framing all of it on either side of you, stone that was cut for cannon. This is a picture that only exists here, so take it if you want it.

The opening itself is a cheat. The Gate of the Virgin was cut through the sea wall in nineteen fifty-five for traffic, on a plan the Italians drew. The Knights had no gate here. Their harbour gates were the small Mills Gate just to the north, which led out to the grain mills on the mole, and the great twin-towered Marine Gate beyond it, which you will meet in a few minutes. This breach is named for the church just inside it, and that church is the reason we came in this way.

A word about who built the wall you are standing in. The Knights Hospitaller of Saint John began as a hospital in Jerusalem, became a religious order, then a military one, lost the Holy Land, spent a few years on Cyprus, and in thirteen ten took Rhodes from the Byzantines after a four-year siege of their own. For the next two hundred and twelve years this island was their sovereign state, and this town was its capital. They were expelled from here in fifteen twenty-three, and only afterward became the Knights of Malta. So everything you will see of them today is the original: the Malta you may know is the sequel.

They built for siege because sieges came: four kilometres of wall, a dry moat up to thirty metres wide, walls twelve metres thick in places, and a ring of round bastions added every time a new kind of gun appeared. You will walk on top of those walls at noon.

Now turn back to the arch. When you walk through it, the twenty-first century stays behind you. The lane on the other side leads into the oldest surviving neighbourhood of the town, and the first thing you meet is a church with no roof. Go.

03 • A Church Without a Roof

Our Lady of the Burgh (Panagia tou Bourgou)

On your left, just inside the gate, is a church with the sky for a ceiling. Our Lady of the Burgh, fourteenth century, Gothic, three apses still standing against the blue, the pointed arches of a cathedral nave with nothing on top of them.

Step inside the arches if the gate is open. Stand in what was the nave. Close your eyes for ten seconds and put the roof back on: the choir, the candle smoke, the stone reverb of a cold building full of people. ... Now open them again. Just wind, sea, and a cat. Rhodes uses buildings until they fall down, and then it uses the pieces.

The Burgh, the Bourgo, was the lower town, the merchants' town. The Knights lived in their own walled quarter on the hill to the north, the Collachium, and nobody who was not a member of the Order was allowed to sleep there overnight. Everyone else, the Greeks, the Latin traders, the Jews, lived down here, ruled but not admitted. This church was theirs, the Latin church of the lower town, and it was already old when the Knights lost the island.

After fifteen twenty-two the Greeks were moved out of the walls altogether into suburbs, the churches became mosques, and enclosed wooden balconies were hung over these lanes. In the twentieth century the Italians tore the balconies down again to make the town look medieval, which it had never quite been. In nineteen forty-four Allied bombs fell on this quarter. The church lost whatever the centuries had left it. What you are looking at is honest ruin, and it is one of the most beautiful things in the town.

This is also the doorway to the Juderia, the Jewish quarter, which is a five-minute walk south of here. We will come back to it after noon, when the synagogue is open, and we will give it a track of its own, a more hushed one than the others. For now, turn west, away from the sea, and follow the lanes toward the square with the fountain and the stone owl. It is about four minutes. The town wakes up as you go.

04 • The Law Is Lord of the Sea

Marine Gate (Thalassini Pyli)

You are in Hippocrates Square, the heart of the lower town, where the bazaar street comes down the hill and the harbour gate opens to the water. The building with the outside stone staircase is the Castellania, built in fifteen oh seven, the Knights' courthouse, where the Order judged the merchants it taxed. A stone owl sits on the fountain. Ignore anyone waving a laminated menu at you on this square. The honest kitchens are one lane away, on a quiet street called Sofokleous, and lunch is already planned there. But note the little doorway under the courthouse stairs. Since nineteen sixty-three a family has run a cellar there that pours Rhodian wine by the glass to drink on the steps, and sells the island's grape spirit, souma, at shop prices. That is a later stop. Now walk the fifty metres north to the gate with the two round towers facing the harbour. This is the Marine Gate, built by Grand Master Pierre d'Aubusson in fourteen seventy-eight, as much for show as defence; look for the saints carved above the arch. Its north tower was shattered by Allied bombing and rebuilt in nineteen fifty-one. From this quay, on the first of January fifteen twenty-three, the Knights sailed away for good, with drums beating and four thousand townspeople who chose exile with them. You will hear that story on the walls.

Stand under the arch and look at the water. This gate is the right place to hear about the oldest thing Rhodes gave the world, which was not the statue but its law of the sea.

Two thousand years ago Rhodes ran the biggest merchant fleet in the eastern Mediterranean, and it wrote rules for it. One survived into Roman law and is still in every marine insurance policy on earth. If cargo is thrown overboard to save a ship, everyone whose goods were saved shares the loss. Lawyers call it general average. The Romans called it the Rhodian law.

There is a story about it in the Digest of Justinian. A merchant named Eudaemon was shipwrecked off an island and robbed by the islanders, and he petitioned the emperor Antoninus. The emperor wrote back: I

am, indeed, the Lord of the World. But the Law is the Lord of the sea, and this affair must be decided by the Rhodian law.

Everything else you will see today is about people trying to take this town by force, but this gate is a reminder that for a few centuries Rhodes ruled the water with a rule book instead.

When you are ready, go back through the gate and follow the lane north along the inside of the wall. In about three minutes it opens into Museum Square, and the great building on your left is the reason the Knights existed at all.

05 • The Hospital

Hospital of the Knights (Archaeological Museum)

The building filling the south side of Museum Square, and the whole left-hand side of the street that climbs away from it, is the Hospital of the Knights, and it really was a hospital. It was begun in fourteen forty on the ruins of a Roman building and finished in fourteen eighty-nine under Grand Master d'Aubusson, whose name you will keep hearing today.

Above the door, two angels hold the arms of Grand Master Fluvian, who left the money. Inside, a courtyard with a stone lion and a heap of stone cannonballs, then a monumental stair to the first floor. The great ward up there is a hall divided by seven octagonal pillars, with a chapel apse at the end, isolation cells along the sides and a cedar ceiling. It held about a hundred patients, tended by the knights themselves.

The Order of Saint John began in Jerusalem as a hospice for pilgrims, became a religious order, then a military one, then a sovereign state, but the vow that defined them was to serve, in their own phrase, our lords the sick. The tongue of France, the richest of the eight national chapters, held the office of Hospitaller, master of this house. A young knight who arrived on Rhodes had to serve his turn here and sail three patrols on the Order's galleys before he could hope for a posting home. They were warrior monks, but the building they were proudest of was this one.

It is now the Archaeological Museum, and three things inside belong to today's story.

First, the marble head of Helios, the sun god, over life size, second century before Christ. Look at the hair, windswept and drilled with holes; those held a bronze crown of rays. This is the closest surviving thing to the face of the Colossus, and it was found on the hill at the top of this street, where the Palace now stands. This head comes back into the story when we get up to the Palace.

Second, the Aphrodite of Rhodes: a small crouching Venus, half a metre high, wringing the sea out of her hair and looking straight at you. Found in nineteen twenty-three in the governor's garden.

Third, the Marine Venus, a standing Aphrodite fished out of the harbour in nineteen twenty-nine, her face worn smooth by the sea. She was hidden in a crypt during the war. In nineteen forty-five the writer Lawrence Durrell, who was living in a gatekeeper's lodge in an Ottoman cemetery on the far side of town, watched her come out. I can still see the faces of my friends, he wrote, as they surrounded the dark trap door out of which she rose so gravely into the sunlight. He named his book about Rhodes after her.

One practical note. Another cruise ship has been in port since seven. Go in now, while the alleys are still quiet. Give it forty-five minutes. The Prehistoric rooms are open today; the Epigraphical rooms are not, so do not hunt for them. When you come out, turn left up the cobbled street. That climb is the next track.

06 • Seven Tongues

Street of the Knights (Odos Ippoton)

Start walking uphill. Slowly. This is the Street of the Knights, the Odos Ippoton, two hundred metres long, six metres wide, cobbled, rising gently west from the Hospital to the Palace. It is the spine of the Collachium, the walled quarter where only members of the Order could sleep, and it is the most complete medieval street in the eastern Mediterranean. In nineteen sixteen the Italians stripped off the Ottoman wooden balconies to make it look the way it did in fourteen ninety. The stone, the arches and the coats of arms are original.

Here is how the Order worked, because this street is its organisation chart carved in stone. The Knights were divided by nation into chapters called tongues, langues: Provence, Auvergne, France, Italy, Aragon, England, and Germany, and after fourteen sixty-two an eighth, Castile. Each tongue lived in its own inn, ate together, and defended its own stretch of the city wall. And the head of each tongue held one of the great offices by right of his nation. Provence gave the Grand Commander, the treasurer. Auvergne gave the Marshal, who commanded the army. France gave the Hospitaller. Italy gave the Admiral. Aragon the standard-bearer. England the Turcopolier, the captain of the light cavalry and the coast watch. Germany the Grand Bailiff, in charge of the walls. Castile the Chancellor. A game designer would be embarrassed to invent it.

Now read the street as you climb. Right-hand side, first building, the Inn of Italy, fifteen nineteen. The shield in the centre of the facade belongs to Grand Master Fabrizio del Carretto, the last Grand Master to die on Rhodes, a year before the final siege.

Next on the right, the Inn of France, the richest facade here, restored around fourteen ninety-two after the first siege. It has a corner turret, the arms of d'Aubusson with his cardinal's hat, and three plaques of Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, the last Grand Master of Rhodes. And look up at the roofline. Crocodiles. Those gargoyles commemorate the dragon that a Grand Master killed in the fourteenth century, and you will meet it at the

top of the hill, at the gate where its skull hung. Four of the last five Grand Masters were Frenchmen, two of them from this house. Chateaubriand admired the lilies of France here, as fresh as if they came from the hand of the sculptor.

Beside the Inn of France is a tiny Gothic chapel, thirteen sixty-five, with the arms of the Pope framed by the lions of England; it began as the English chapel. Then the chaplain's house, with ten shields on its lintel, a who's who of fourteenth-century Grand Masters.

Left-hand side, near the top, is the Inn of Spain, one of the largest, with the shields of Castile, Aragon, Granada, Navarre and Portugal. Joined to it by the arch that bridges the street is the Inn of Provence, fifteen eighteen, the oldest tongue and the Grand Commander's seat.

Every shield on this street is a signature. The street ends in a vaulted arcade, the Loggia of Saint John, and opens onto the Palace forecourt. Stop under the arcade. The next track is about what used to stand on your left.

07 • The Vault

Site of St John of the Collachium (the vault that exploded)

Look left from the top of the street, past the Ottoman clock tower, to the neoclassical school building. Under that school, where only scraps of foundation show beside it, lie the remains of the Church of Saint John of the Collachium, the Order's own church, begun in thirteen ten, a year after they took the island.

This was the heart of the Order's faction on the island. The Grand Masters were crowned here and buried here, at least six of them, including the dragon-slayer Dieudonné de Gozon, whose plain tomb slab was dug up and shipped to Paris in eighteen seventy-seven; it sits today in the Musée de Cluny. This was also the treasury, holding the relics the Order had carried out of the Holy Land: a fragment of the True Cross, the icon of Our Lady of Philermos, credited with saving the city in fourteen eighty, and, attested in this church from fourteen thirteen, the right hand of John the Baptist himself, the hand that baptised Christ.

Follow that hand for a moment, because its journey is the best artifact story on the island. It left Rhodes with the Knights in fifteen twenty-three and went to Malta. When Napoleon took Malta in seventeen ninety-eight, the Knights handed it to the Tsar of Russia, who dressed the icon in diamonds. When the revolution came, the Dowager Empress carried the relics out through Copenhagen, and later they went to the King of Yugoslavia in Belgrade. They were hidden in a mountain monastery in nineteen forty-one, seized by the communist police in nineteen fifty-one, and locked in a vault in Cetinje, Montenegro; their survival was revealed only in nineteen ninety-three. The hand is in a monastery in Cetinje today. It has been a nine-century game of keep-away, and it started in the ground you are looking at.

After the conquest of fifteen twenty-two the church became the town's main mosque, and at some point somebody stored gunpowder in the cellars under its bell tower. On the sixth of November eighteen fifty-six, lightning struck the tower, and the church vanished in a single blast that tore the upper floors off the Palace behind you and brought down

much of the Knights' quarter. At least two hundred people died, and the British vice-consul, an amateur archaeologist named Biliotti, spent days digging for survivors. The clock tower you can see today was rebuilt afterward, and seventy years later the Italians built a copy of the lost church from old engravings down at the harbour, which you will walk past this afternoon.

If you play tabletop games, you will recognise the shape of it, a reliquary chapel sitting over a forgotten powder magazine, a trap with a three-hundred-and-thirty-four-year fuse.

Now turn right, to the gate with the two horseshoe towers. That is the Palace of the Grand Master, and the hill it stands on may be the most argued-about piece of ground on the island.

08 • The Keep on the Sun's Hill

Palace of the Grand Master

You are standing in front of the Palace of the Grand Master. Walk through the gate between the two horseshoe towers into the courtyard, and let me tell you what you are actually looking at, because it is not quite what it looks like.

The hill was a Byzantine citadel in the seventh century, and the Knights made it their headquarters after thirteen oh nine, a fortress roughly eighty metres square around a courtyard, with grain silos along one side for sieges. Then the powder magazine under the church next door went up in eighteen fifty-six, and for eighty years this was a ruin.

What you walk through today was built between nineteen thirty-seven and nineteen forty by the Italian governor of the Dodecanese, as a holiday residence for King Victor Emmanuel the Third and for Mussolini, and neither of them ever slept here. The architect worked from the outside walls inward and invented most of the rest, and critics at the time called it horrible fascist taste. The floors upstairs are paved with Hellenistic and Roman mosaics lifted from the island of Kos in the nineteen thirties, including the Nine Muses, the Medusa in the colonnaded hall, and a nymph on a sea-horse. There is also a full-size cast of the Laocoön, the marble group of a priest and his sons strangled by sea serpents, carved by three sculptors from Rhodes and one of the most famous statues in the world. Jewish tombstones from the town cemetery were requisitioned for the building work too. So the Palace has belonged to one regime after another: a Byzantine fort, a crusader keep, an exploded ruin, and a dictator's unused summer house.

Downstairs is the exhibition Ancient Rhodes, Two Thousand Four Hundred Years, open today. Look for the stone shot, the great round balls fired from Demetrius' siege engines in three hundred and five BC. That siege is the one that paid for the Colossus, and I will tell that story at the harbour this afternoon.

Now, the hill itself. For seven hundred years people have argued about where the Colossus stood, and most of them have looked at the harbour.

In twenty twenty-four an Oxford monograph by Nathan Badoud, which reviewers are calling the definitive study, argued that the sanctuary of Helios, the sun god's sacred area, was here, on this small hill at the head of the Knights' quarter. An inscription naming the sacred area of Helios, dedications by his priests, and that marble head you saw in the Hospital were all found on this hill, and a statue here would have been visible from the Anatolian coast, which Rhodes then ruled. So when you stand in the courtyard, try to see a bronze youth a hundred feet tall where the towers are. We will come back to this at the harbour, and the answer will point up here.

One practical note. Buy the walls-walk ticket at the desk when you buy the Palace ticket. The rampart walk runs only from noon to three on weekdays, and if you leave the Palace and come back for it you pay the twenty euros again, so go in around eleven and stay. Last admission is twenty minutes before closing. There is one more stop before noon, five minutes away, out through the small gate on the west side of the forecourt to the great gate beyond it, and you will want to look up when you get there.

09 • Draconis Extinctor

D'Amboise Gate (the dragon's head)

You are under the arch of the d'Amboise Gate, finished in fifteen twelve by Grand Master Emery d'Amboise, the grandest gate in the whole circuit. A marble angel holds the arms of the Order, and there are slots in the twin round towers where the drawbridge chains ran. Behind you the road bends through three more gates before it reaches the town, which is why the Ottomans called it the Crooked Gate, a killing corridor with cannon at ground level.

Now look up at the arch, because local tradition says that until about eighteen thirty-seven a skull hung over this gate, and it was the skull of a dragon.

The tale has been told since the sixteenth century like this. Around thirteen forty, under Grand Master Héliion de Villeneuve, a monster made its lair in the marsh and caves at Malpasso, the bad passage, on the coast road a couple of kilometres south-west of here, under the hill they now call Monte Smith. It ate cattle, it ate shepherds, and knights who rode out after it did not come back. The Grand Master forbade any further attempt, on pain of expulsion.

A young knight from Provence, Dieudonné de Gozon, went home to his father's castle in France. He built a dragon of wood and canvas, hid meat under its belly, and for months trained two mastiffs to dart at the soft underside, and his horse to charge it. Then he came back to Rhodes and rode out with two squires. His lance shattered on the scales. The dogs hung on the belly, and he drove his sword into the one place it could go. The dying beast fell on him, and the squires revived him with cold water. Villeneuve stripped him of the habit for disobedience, then, moved by his humility, gave it back. In thirteen forty-six Gozon became Grand Master. His epitaph, the story says, read Draconis Extinctor, slayer of the dragon. Schiller made a ballad of it in seventeen ninety-eight whose moral was obedience.

Now here is the historian's version. In nineteen thirteen a British scholar named Hasluck went looking for the sources. He found nothing before

fifteen twenty-one, and in that account the hero has no name. The name Gozon was first attached by Bosio, writing in Rome in the fifteen nineties. A French traveller in the sixteen fifties saw a head over a gate, larger than a horse's, with a huge mouth and teeth and very large eyes, and every later witness who described it used the same word, crocodile, though some said hippopotamus. Hasluck's explanation is that Gozon had marched in French religious processions where a model dragon, the spirit of evil, was ritually slain, and the parade turned into a biography. And there is an older story under that one. Pliny lists the island's ancient names, and one of them is Ophiussa, the snaky one. Diodorus says Rhodes was once infested with serpents until the oracle of Apollo told the people to summon a Thessalian named Phorbas, who killed them and was honoured as a hero ever after. So Rhodes was the snake island before it was the dragon island, and it is the same story with an older monster.

So you have a quest forbidden by your own order, training on a dummy, and a crocodile skull over the city gate. Decide for yourself. Then go back through the three gates the way you came, to the Palace forecourt, where the iron gate to the ramparts opens at noon.

10 • The Faction Map

Walls walk: iron gate on the Palace forecourt

You are on top of the wall. It is wide enough for two carts, they say, and there are no railings on the inside, so keep to the middle and look where you step. Walk south, with the moat on your right. This is a faction map, and you are walking across it.

The Order divided the circuit among its tongues, and each tongue's arms are carved on its stretch. From the Palace the first post was France, then Germany, whose Grand Bailiff was responsible for all the fortifications. Below you now is the pentagonal Bastion of Saint George, wrapped around an old gate that d'Aubusson walled shut after the first siege and given its final form by an engineer from Vicenza before the second. Historians call it a prototype of the angled bastion, the shape that would define European fortresses for three hundred years, and the earth bank behind it, the terreplein of Spain, was honeycombed with galleries built to be collapsed on any attacker who got inside.

The next post is Auvergne, the Marshal's tongue, and then the Tower of Spain, the first of the big fights on this walk. Rhodes was besieged twice by the Ottoman Empire. The first time, in fourteen eighty, it held. The second time, in fifteen twenty-two, Sultan Suleiman came in person, with something like a hundred thousand men and four hundred ships, against about seven hundred knights and six thousand soldiers. On the twenty-fourth of September, the day of the great general assault, the Janissaries took this tower by midday and planted their banners on the rampart you are walking on. A knight named Jacques de Bourbon led his brothers back through the underground passages and retook it. It changed hands twice more before Suleiman called off the attack and sentenced his own commander to death, then relented.

Now comes the long straight stretch ahead of you, England's post, between the gate of Saint Athanasios and the gate of Saint John. The Ottomans had brought thousands of miners, and they dug forty or more tunnels under the moat you are looking at. The defenders' answer was a Venetian engineer named Gabriele Tadini, smuggled out of Crete against

orders in July. He pressed a drum with bells hung on its skin against the walls of his own galleries, and when the bells rang he knew where the enemy picks were biting, then he either broke into their tunnel and fought in the dark, or blew it from below. On the fourth of September two mines got through and opened a twelve-yard breach in this wall, and the English brothers and the Grand Master in person held it all day. On the fourteenth of October Tadini took an arquebus ball through the eye while looking through a gun slit. Six weeks after the wound he was leading a sortie, and Titian later painted him with one eye.

Then there is the treason story. The Chancellor of the Order, Andrea d'Amaral, who had lost the election for Grand Master the year before, was accused after his servant was caught on the ramparts with a bow and a letter to shoot into the enemy lines. The servant was hanged and quartered, and d'Amaral, who refused to confess under torture, was stripped of his habit in the church of Saint John and beheaded. Portuguese historians call him a scapegoat, so keep both versions in mind.

By December the powder was gone, and the Spanish tower had fallen for good. On the twenty-second the town accepted terms. The Knights could leave with their arms, their relics, and their honour, the churches were not to be desecrated, and the islanders would pay no tax for five years. Suleiman rode in on Christmas Day. On the first of January fifteen twenty-three, fifty ships sailed from the harbour with drums beating, carrying the Order, four thousand Rhodians who chose to go with it, and a new banner showing the Virgin with her dead son and the motto *Afflictis spes mea rebus*, in my afflictions, my hope. Seven years later the Emperor gave them Malta.

The last posts are Provence, and then Italy at the harbour corner, where the first siege had broken through in fourteen eighty. You will hear that one from below, at the round bastion. The walk ends at the Gate of Saint John, the Kokkini Porta, the Red Gate, so called, the legend says, because the blood of fifteen twenty-two dyed its stones. Steep concrete steps at the end. The Jewish quarter is five minutes north of where you come down.

11 • La Juderia

Kahal Shalom Synagogue and Jewish Museum

Two streets north of the Red Gate, on the corner of Dosiadou and Simiou streets, is Kahal Shalom, built in fifteen seventy-seven, the oldest synagogue in Greece. Go in; it is open until three, six euros, and the museum is in the old women's prayer rooms beside it. This track is more hushed than the others, and it ends in silence. Let it.

Jews have lived on Rhodes for more than two thousand years. In fifteen twenty-three, the year the Knights left, the Ottomans resettled a hundred and fifty Jewish families from Salonica in this quarter, and for four centuries this was the Juderia, a Sephardic community, descended from the Jews expelled from Spain, speaking Ladino, the old Spanish of their grandparents, in these lanes. By nineteen thirty about four thousand of the island's thirty thousand people were Jewish, and there were six synagogues here. Inside, look at the plan, the reading platform in the centre, the Sephardic way, and, unusually, two Torah arks. This is the only one of the quarter's synagogues to survive the Allied bombing of nineteen forty-four.

Then things changed. Italy's racial laws of nineteen thirty-eight drove more than two thousand people to emigrate. In September nineteen forty-three the Germans took the island from the Italians. On the eighteenth of July nineteen forty-four the German command ordered every Jewish male over sixteen to report the next morning to the Air Force headquarters with his papers, and the women and children followed with their valuables. On the twenty-third of July, one thousand six hundred and seventy-three people were marched from the square just ahead of you to the harbour you landed in this morning, and packed into three boats. About a hundred Jews from the island of Kos were added on the way. Seven died in the eight-day crossing to Piraeus, and from there they were sent by rail, reaching Auschwitz on the sixteenth of August nineteen forty-four. About a hundred and fifty came back.

One man in Rhodes said no. Selahattin Ülkümen, the Turkish consul, twenty-nine years old, went to the German general and argued that

under Turkish law all citizens are equal, and stretched his consular protection over people with lapsed papers and over the spouses of Turkish citizens. He saved between forty and fifty people. His wife was fatally injured when the consulate was bombed. In nineteen eighty-nine Israel named him Righteous Among the Nations.

When you come out, walk to the square, called the Square of the Jewish Martyrs. The bronze seahorses on the fountain are the square's older, gentler landmark. The black six-sided memorial, dedicated in two thousand and two, speaks in six languages, English, French, Greek, Hebrew, Italian, and Ladino.

About forty Jews live on Rhodes today. Survivor Samuel Modiano said of that month, instead of killing us on the spot, on our island, we were transported to the camps and murdered in secret. ...

This track ends here. When you are ready, lunch is three minutes away, on a calm street where the noise of the bazaar stops.

12 • Lunch on Sofokleous

Lunch: Nireas, Sofokleous 22

Sofokleous is the one calm, good street in the walled town. The bazaar noise stops right at the corner, and you can hear it happen. This is where lunch is, and since it is your birthday, the album stops here for a while.

Nireas, at number twenty-two, has belonged to the Tsikis family since nineteen eighty-nine. You eat under a pergola of jasmine, honeysuckle and bougainvillea, with a grapevine overhead that has been growing across the tables for twenty-five years, on a little square where the noise simply ends. The dishes people mention again and again are the Symi shrimp, tiny and sweet, from the island you can see on a clear day, along with scallops, calamari, grilled dorade and shrimp saganaki. Then come the homemade desserts, and this is the part that makes it a real birthday: panna cotta with figs, or the chocolate mousse cake. Ask for the candle.

If you would rather have the plated, celebratory version, Romios at number fifteen is fifty metres away. The chef-owner, Silouani Vlachou, was born on the island and revives forgotten Rhodian recipes: lamb kapamas, which is the Easter roast of the villages, then cuttlefish risotto, and octopus with orange. She plates them, in her own words, as art pieces, in a lantern-lit garden.

Whichever one you choose, order pitaroudia as well, for the quest. These are big, plump fritters of ground chickpeas with onion, grated tomato and spearmint, shallow-fried. They are the island's national dish, and a lunch order rather than something you buy in a shop, so this is the place. And if there is souma on the table, the island's clear grape spirit from the mountain villages, it is being distilled this very week, right after the harvest. A shot over two ice cubes turns milky. It smells of grape, not aniseed.

A few facts to go with the food, since you have time. Rhodian cooking uses bulgur where the rest of Greece uses rice, cumin in fillings and doughs, sesame on everything, and honey to bind rather than sugar. The most Rhodian sweet of all is melekouni, a soft diamond of honey and toasted sesame with almonds and spice, which was the official treat at

village weddings and was sent to relatives who could not attend, the way sugared almonds are elsewhere. It comes with a wish: may you live as many years as there are sesame seeds in the piece. You will buy one on the way up the bazaar street after lunch, and eat it later on the mole with that wish attached.

Take your time. The clock tower is open all afternoon, the mosque and the library are three minutes from the top of the bazaar, and Mandraki is not going anywhere. When you are done, walk north to Hippocrates Square and turn left up Sokratous, the bazaar street, toward the pink mosque at the top. The next track starts under the minaret.

13 • Under the Minaret

Roloi clock tower, Suleymaniye and the Ottoman library

At the top of Sokratous, the old bazaar street, the lane opens and there is a rose-pink mosque with a tall thin minaret. This is the Suleymaniye, the first mosque of the conquest, raised right after fifteen twenty-two on the site of a church whose columns you can still see in the portico. What stands here is the rebuild of eighteen oh eight. The minaret was pulled down as unsafe in nineteen eighty-seven and put back in a restoration that ran until two thousand and five. The interior has been closed since twenty fourteen and opens only irregularly. Look from outside.

This is where the story changes operating system. On the twenty-second of December fifteen twenty-two the town accepted Suleiman's terms. On Christmas Day the Sultan rode in, by tradition through the Gate of Saint Athanasios on the south wall, and came as far as the church of Saint John. Then he had that gate sealed, so that nobody could ever use his door again. It stayed shut for four hundred years, until nineteen twenty-two. On the twenty-ninth of December he came in again by the Red Gate, went down to the harbour, and admired the great chain that closed it. On the last day of the year he received the Grand Master in his tent, a man of nearly sixty who had held out for six months, and, the story says, told his vizier it was not without some compunction that he compelled this venerable warrior at his age to seek a new home. That last line is later tradition. The rest is record.

For the next three hundred and ninety years this was an Ottoman town. The Greeks were moved outside the walls into suburbs. The churches became mosques, the Jews stayed inside, wooden balconies went up over the alleys, hammams and fountains appeared, and the Knights' inns became houses and bathhouses. The city you have been walking through is not a medieval city. It is four cities stacked on top of each other, and the Ottoman one is the thickest.

Across the lane from the mosque is the Hafiz Ahmed Agha Library, founded in seventeen ninety-three by a village boy from this island who rose to become the Sultan's chief equerry and endowed it, in his own

words, for the literate public of his hometown. He even paid the librarians to teach Arabic so that people could read the books. About twelve hundred and sixty manuscripts survive inside, among them a Koran of fifteen forty and a chronicle of the siege of fifteen twenty-two, written by the winning side. The courtyard is free if the door is open; the hours are posted on the door and nowhere else, and one recent visitor found it locked because the man with the door code had gone to the hairdresser. If you play games, this is the town's arcane library, and the custodian literally holds the key.

And beside you is the Roloji, the clock tower, built in eighteen fifty-two by an Ottoman governor on a Byzantine base and rebuilt after the explosion four years later. It is fifty-three steep wooden steps up to a tiny chamber with four small windows. Look north to the Palace, west to the acropolis hill, east to the harbour and your own ship, and south-east to the minaret you are standing under. The ticket is five euros and includes a drink in the courtyard bar, beer, wine, coffee or juice, which makes it the obvious place for the birthday toast. Only about four people fit at the top. Go up, and have the drink at the bottom afterward. Then we go back down the bazaar to buy a relic.

14 • Sorcerer-Smiths

Temple of Aphrodite, Symi Square (the Telchines)

Walk back down the bazaar street, and somewhere between the mosque and the square, in one of the small delis, buy a bar of melekouni, a soft diamond of honey and toasted sesame. Check that the label says PGI, the protected name. It comes with a wish, and you will eat it on the mole. If you see souma, the grape spirit, in a small bottle, that is the other quest item.

At the bottom of the street, cross Hippocrates Square and go north, past Museum Square, to a small open square just inside the Liberty Gate, with a fenced tumble of column drums and blocks in it. That is a temple of Aphrodite, third century before Christ, built within a generation of the Colossus. It is the only ancient temple you can touch inside the walls, and it is the right place to go back before the Knights, the Romans and the statue, to the beginning.

Strabo says the island was once called Telchinis, after the Telchines who lived there. Diodorus says they were children of the Sea who nursed the infant Poseidon, and that they were the first to work iron and bronze. They forged the sickle with which Cronus unmanned the sky, and later tradition adds the trident of Poseidon too. They were also the first to make statues of the gods, and they could summon clouds, rain, hail and even snow at will, and change their own shape. They were jealous of teaching their arts to anyone. Strabo's other tradition calls them maligners and sorcerers who poured the water of the Styx, mixed with sulphur, on animals and crops to kill them. Ovid gives them the evil eye, eyes whose corrupting power shot forth, so that Jupiter, in disgust, thrust them under his brother's waves. Diodorus says they foresaw the flood and left.

This is why the story belongs at this ruin. A Telchine named Halia bore Poseidon six sons and a daughter. When Aphrodite, sailing from Cythera to Cyprus, tried to land on Rhodes, the arrogant sons drove her away, and the goddess, in her wrath, brought madness on them. Their mother threw herself into the sea. The daughter was Rhodos. When the gods

drew lots for the earth, Helios the sun was away driving his chariot and got no share. Offered a second draw, he refused, because he had seen, growing from the bottom of the grey sea, a rich land for men. He claimed the rising island, married Rhodos, and named the island after her. Their seven sons were astrologer-kings who invented the division of the day into hours. The cleverest was murdered by his brothers out of envy, the murderers fled to other islands, and the ones who stayed behind named the three cities.

So that is what you have here: a lost guild of artificer-warlocks, weather magic, the sickle of Cronus, a goddess's curse, a divine flood, and a sun god who won an island by declining a lottery. That is the mythic bedrock, and everything else, the Knights, the Sultan and the Italians, is built on top of it.

Now, thirty metres north, the Liberty Gate. The Italians cut it through the wall in nineteen twenty-four and named it for themselves, as liberators from the Ottomans. When you walk through it, you leave the medieval city, and the score opens up to the sea, the sky, the boulevard and the harbour. Go through.

15 • The City-Taker

Liberty Gate (1924)

You are outside the walls now, on the wide boulevard along Mandraki harbour that the Italians laid out in the nineteen twenties and called the Foro Italico. Walk north, with the water on your right. The buildings on your left are a stage set. Italy took the island from the Ottomans in nineteen twelve and kept it until nineteen forty-seven, and the governor's architect, Florestano Di Fausto, built a garden city here in a style he called Mediterranean-ness: the seven-sided market with the domed fish pavilion in its courtyard, closed this year for restoration; the Bank of Greece, once the Banca d'Italia, dressed up in Knights' masonry; the Governor's Palace, striped pink and white, a straight copy of the Doge's Palace in Venice; and the Gothic church of the Annunciation, rebuilt from old engravings of the Knights' church of Saint John that blew up in eighteen fifty-six, so that an occupying power could look as if it had always belonged here.

Now walk, and let me tell you about the machine.

In three hundred and five BC, when the sea assault on the harbour behind you failed, Demetrius the Besieger turned to the land walls and built the Helepolis, the City-Taker. Diodorus gives its stats. A base almost fifty cubits square, framed of squared timber fastened with iron. Eight solid wheels, each rim two cubits wide and overlaid with heavy iron plates. Corner posts nearly a hundred cubits high, nine storeys, each floor with shuttered ports shaped to the missiles it fired, stone-throwers below and dart-throwers above. The three exposed sides were covered with iron plates nailed on so that it should receive no injury from fire carriers. And it took three thousand four hundred men excelling in strength to move it. Plutarch, who gives lower numbers, marvelled that it did not totter or lean when it moved but advanced evenly, with much noise and great impetus. Vitruvius weighs it at three hundred and sixty thousand Roman pounds, about a hundred and eighteen tonnes.

Here are three ways to stop a siege construct, and all three are attested. One night, at about the second watch, the Rhodians hit it with an

unremitting shower of fire missiles until the iron plates were dislodged and the wood beneath began to burn; Demetrius dragged it out of range, and at dawn his men counted more than eight hundred fire missiles and fifteen hundred catapult bolts on the ground. Underground, a Rhodian counter-mine met his sappers, and a citizen named Athenagoras pretended to betray the city and lured a senior officer up through the tunnel to be captured. And Vitruvius tells the third. The city's engineer Diognetus had a hole cut in the wall opposite the tower and had every citizen pour through it all the water, filth and mud that could be procured, so that when the Helepolis advanced, it sank into the quagmire. In defensive operations, Vitruvius concludes, ingenuity is of more avail than machines.

Peace came in three hundred and four. Rhodes stayed free, ungarrisoned, and kept its revenue. Demetrius sailed away and left his engines behind, and the Rhodians sold them for three hundred talents. The wonder of the world was the scrap value of a failed siege: with the money they commissioned Chares of Lindos, a pupil of Alexander's own sculptor, to build a bronze Helios seventy cubits high. It took twelve years to finish.

You will see the deer columns ahead at the harbour mouth. That is where the statue's story ends, and where everyone has always placed its feet. Go there.

16 • Where Was the Colossus?

The deer columns, Mandraki harbour mouth

Two limestone columns stand at the harbour mouth, a bronze stag on one and a bronze doe on the other, sixty-two metres of water between them. They were put up in nineteen thirty-nine by the Italian administration, and every postcard and every guide will tell you that the Colossus of Rhodes stood astride this entrance with ships passing between its legs. Stand here and read the dedication carved on its pedestal, because that part, at least, is real: To thy very self, O Sun, did the people of Dorian Rhodes raise high to heaven this colossus, when, having laid to rest the brazen wave of war, they crowned their country with the spoils of their foes. Not only over the sea, but on the land too, did they establish the lovely light of unfettered freedom.

Now, the facts. Chares of Lindos finished it around two hundred and eighty BC. It was thirty-three metres of bronze plate over an iron frame, braced inside with stone, a nude youth with long curling hair and a crown of rays, the same Helios that appears on Rhodian coins. There was no torch; the torch was invented by a Dutch engraver in fifteen seventy-two. It stood for about sixty-six years, until an earthquake broke it at the knees. The King of Egypt offered three thousand talents and a hundred master builders to raise it again, but an oracle told the Rhodians not to, so they left the god lying there for centuries. Pliny the Elder saw it: even lying on the ground it is a marvel. Few people can make their arms meet round the thumb, and the fingers are larger than most statues; where the limbs have broken off, enormous cavities yawn, and inside are seen great masses of rock with the weight of which the artist steadied it. Nobody in antiquity wrote down where it lay.

The picture of the statue straddling the harbour is medieval. Its earliest trace is a notary from Campania named Niccolò de Martoni, who came through in thirteen ninety-four and wrote down what the locals told him: one foot stood on the end of the mole where the church of Saint Nicholas was, and the other on the mole where the mills are. Look across the water. The fort at the end of the mole sits on the church's site, and

the windmills are on the other mole, several hundred metres away, far too much for a thirty-three metre figure to stride. Engineers add that bronze legs splayed even twelve metres would buckle under the weight, and that a statue which fell across the harbour mouth would have closed the port, whereas Pliny walked around it on land. The picture was fixed forever in fifteen seventy-two, when Philips Galle engraved Maarten van Heemskerck's design of the sun god bestriding the harbour with a smoking torch, and it descended from there into Shakespeare, he doth bestride the narrow world like a colossus, and into Emma Lazarus's poem on the Statue of Liberty, not like the brazen giant of Greek fame, with conquering limbs astride from land to land.

The best-loved version of what happened next goes like this. In the year six hundred and fifty-four, the Arabs overran Rhodes, sold the bronze to a Jewish merchant of Edessa, and he carried it away on nine hundred camels. One source says nine hundred and eighty. Every version traces back to a single lost chronicle, the arithmetic does not work, a pagan bronze scrapheap is unlikely to have survived the Christian centuries, and the newest study calls it a fabrication modelled on the shattered statue in the Book of Daniel. Nine hundred camels is still the best line in the story, so keep it as a story.

There are three answers to where it actually stood. Under the floor of the fort at the end of the mole there is a ring of sandstone blocks nobody can explain, and finely cut curved marble reused in its walls; a German scholar argued in two thousand and three that the pedestal was there. On the acropolis hill to the west, the one with the four columns, another scholar re-identified the temple as the sanctuary of Helios and the ruin beside it as the statue's base and workshop. And in twenty twenty-four, in what reviewers call the definitive study, Nathan Badoud put the sanctuary of Helios on the small hill at the head of the Knights' quarter, where an inscription naming the sacred area of Helios, dedications by his priests, and the marble head you saw this morning were all found. That third answer points to the hill under the Palace, where you stood at eleven o'clock, in the courtyard, looking north-east toward the Turkish coast.

Now walk out along the mole to the fort, past the windmills, and turn around. From there you can see the whole impossible stride, the hill, and the ship you came on. Eat the melekouni, and may you live as many years as there are sesame seeds in the piece.

17 • Fort Saint Nicholas

Fort St Nicholas, tip of the Mandraki mole

You are at the end of the mole, and this is Fort Saint Nicholas, a round tower built between fourteen sixty-four and fourteen sixty-seven by Grand Master Zacosta on the site of a chapel of Saint Nicholas, patron of sailors, that was already here in thirteen ninety-four. After the first siege, d'Aubusson wrapped it in the low bastion you can see. A lighthouse has burned on the roof since the sixteen hundreds and still does today. The interior has been under restoration for years, so treat it as closed. The mole itself is public, and the view from here is the best free thing in town. This tower is where the siege of fourteen eighty began. The Ottoman commander was Mesih Pasha, born into the last Byzantine imperial family and probably a nephew of the last emperor of Constantinople. He was taken at the age of ten when that city fell in fourteen fifty-three, converted, raised as a palace page, and sent back twenty-seven years later to besiege Christians for the Sultan. He arrived on the twenty-third of May with about a hundred and sixty ships and seventy thousand men, against perhaps five hundred knights and two thousand soldiers. His first target was this tower, because it controlled both harbours. His big bombards fired at it across the water from the ground around the Ottoman cemetery you can see on the far shore, beside the casino. On the ninth of June the Janissaries stormed it and were thrown back. Then, on the night of the eighteenth of June, they pushed a floating bridge toward the mole for a night assault. According to the Order's own chronicle, an English sailor named Roger Jervis swam out in the dark, found the anchor by which the bridge was to be warped into place, cut the rope and carried the anchor off, so that the bridge drifted useless. The assault that followed cost the Ottomans two or three thousand men. A German engineer who had deserted to the Knights and offered them his marvellous genius turned out to be a spy, and was hanged in the public square. The Ottomans then moved their guns to the weak south-east corner of the walls, by the Jewish quarter, and pounded it to rubble, and on the twenty-seventh of July twenty-five hundred Janissaries got over the

wall. You heard about that from the ramparts. D'Aubusson took a lance through the breastplate, and the attack broke. On the seventeenth of August the fleet sailed away, and Mehmed the Conqueror, who had taken Constantinople, died the following year without ever taking Rhodes. Forty-two years later his great-grandson came back.

Now turn around and look, from left to right. There are the windmills on the mole, three survivors of thirteen that once ground grain for the Knights' galleys, then the great wall with the twin towers of the Marine Gate, the Palace on its hill, where the sun god's sanctuary probably was, the pink-and-white Governor's Palace and the Italian boulevard, and the deer columns at the harbour mouth. Out to the east, on a clear day, are the mountains of Turkey, the Peraia, which Rhodes ruled when the statue was new. Badoud's argument is that the Colossus was placed to be seen from there, a bronze sun over the water, telling the mainland who held dominion, in the epigram's words, both on land and sea.

Behind you is the open sea, and the direction your ship will take tonight. Walk back along the mole. The birthday cocktail is waiting on the quay.

18 • Birthday

Swan by Kontiki (floating bar, Mandraki)

This track has no history in it.

Walk back along the mole, past the windmills, to the inner quay by the closed market, where three floating decks are moored off the square. That is Swan by Kontiki. Go up to the top deck. Order something unnecessary. Face the harbour mouth, so that the fort, the windmills and the walls are all in front of you and the sun is over your shoulder.

You have walked four thousand years today, from a sorcerers' island to a Fascist boulevard, through a hospital, a guild street, an exploded church, a dictator's unused palace, a dragon gate, a mile of ramparts, a synagogue, a bazaar, a mosque and a library, past the impossible feet of a bronze god. And it is your birthday.

[This is where the personal track goes. A song that matters. A message recorded by someone who could not be here, spliced in as a ghost voice. Or thirty seconds of nothing but the harbour.]

When the glass is empty, the last track is the walk back to the ship, along the water, past a broken tower. Take your time. All-aboard is five-thirty, and it is a level fifteen-minute walk.

19 • Return by Sea

Naillac tower stump and St Paul's Gate

Walk south along the quay, with the water on your left, past the gardens outside the walls and the round bastion of Saint Paul's Gate, to the mole that runs out beyond it. The broken stump of masonry at the root of that mole is the last set-piece of the day.

This was the Tower of Naillac, built between thirteen ninety-six and fourteen twenty-one by the Grand Master of that name. It was a square keep forty-six metres high, lighthouse and watchtower, and the anchor of the great chain that closed the commercial harbour every night, the chain Suleiman came down to admire in December fifteen twenty-two. It survived both sieges. It survived the explosion of eighteen fifty-six. Then, at half past nine in the evening on the twenty-second of April eighteen sixty-three, an earthquake of about magnitude seven and a half threw down two thousand houses on the island and split the tower. The Ottoman administration then pulled down the rest of it. It was the last of the fortifications of Rhodes to die, brought down by an earthquake rather than an army.

From here it is a level walk of about twelve minutes along the waterfront to the ship. Let me compress the day as you go.

Helios, the sun, missed the lottery of the gods and claimed this island as it rose from the sea. The Telchines forged the sickle of Cronus and were drowned for their arrogance. Phorbas killed the snakes. Tlepolemus took nine ships to Troy. Demetrius' iron tower sank in the mud, and his scrap paid for a bronze god thirty-three metres tall that stood for sixty-six years and lay in pieces for eight hundred. The Romans came here to learn to speak, Cicero among them, and a young Julius Caesar, who was kidnapped by pirates on the way and read them his poems for thirty-eight days. The Byzantines built the first citadel on the sun god's hill. The Knights came in thirteen ten, ran the island as a guild of eight nations, built a hospital before they built a palace, killed a dragon that was probably a crocodile, held Mehmed's army in fourteen eighty and lost to Suleiman's in fifteen twenty-two, and sailed out of this harbour

with drums beating. The Ottomans moved the Greeks outside the walls and kept the city for four centuries. The Jews of the Juderia spoke the Spanish of their grandparents here until July nineteen forty-four. The Italians rebuilt the Palace for a king who never came, and cut a gate in the wall and named it Liberty. The Greeks took the island back on the seventh of March nineteen forty-eight and named a square for the day. And the tourists, and the cruise ships, and you.

Rhodes is remarkable because nobody ever stopped using it, rather than because it preserves one moment. Every conqueror kept the same walls, the same streets and the same hill, and added to them. You walked down through all of that this morning and back up again this afternoon.

The ship is getting larger ahead of you. Rhodes has spent three thousand years watching ships arrive. This time, you are the one leaving. Sunset is at six fifty-four, from the top deck, with this wall sliding astern. Happy birthday.

20 • B-side: The Killing Ground

Moat entrance at Mandraki (St Paul's Gate gardens)

This is an optional track, a B-side, for the moat. If the day runs long, skip it. If the ship lands you at Akandia, this is the best way to start the morning, from the gate beside the port, and it comes out at Mandraki.

The Knights' moat was never filled with water. It is a dry ditch, roughly thirty metres wide, cut along the whole landward side of the town under walls up to twelve metres thick, with a second, outer wall on the far side and a sloping glacis beyond that. It is now a landscaped park with sandy paths, lawns, an open-air theatre, and stone cannonballs lying where they fell in fourteen eighty and fifteen twenty-two. It is free and open at all hours, lit after dark, with no kiosks inside. Enter by the gardens at Saint Paul's Gate at the Mandraki end, or beside the port at the Akandia Gate, or by the stairways down from the gates of Saint Anthony and Saint Athanasios. Walking the whole thing takes an hour to ninety minutes.

You have heard about these walls from inside, and you may have walked on top of them. Now here is the third view, the one an attacking army had.

Going clockwise from Mandraki, you pass under the twin round towers of the d'Amboise Gate, with the drawbridge slots above you, and then the pentagonal Bastion of Saint George. Stand in the ditch and look up at the sloped face and the low cannon ports at moat level, designed to rake this exact ground at short range. Behind it the terreplein of Spain, an earth-and-stone bank built after fourteen eighty to absorb cannon fire, was honeycombed with galleries designed to be collapsed on any attacker who got inside.

Then the Tower of Spain, where the Janissaries planted their banners at noon on the twenty-fourth of September fifteen twenty-two and were driven off through the tunnels. Then the long English curtain, where forty Ottoman mines came under this ditch and Tadini's drum listened for them. Then the gate of Saint John, the Red Gate. And at the harbour corner, the great round drum of the del Carretto bastion, built by Grand Master Fabrizio del Carretto exactly on the spot where, at dawn on the

twenty-seventh of July fourteen eighty, twenty-five hundred Janissaries took the Tower of Italy and planted their standards, and d'Aubusson climbed his brick retrenchment three times and took five wounds, and the Order's vice-chancellor, Caoursin, reported that the Turks saw above the wall a splendid golden cross and a virgin all in white carrying a shield and spear, and broke. How else, Caoursin asked, could so small an army overcome such a powerful enemy? It was printed within months and became a European bestseller, and it was propaganda, brilliantly done. Walk inside the bastion if it is open, and feel how thick the cannon platform is. The bastion is the scar tissue.

The Akandia Gate beside it was cut by the Italians in nineteen thirty-five and brings you out beside the port, five minutes from the ship.

21 • B-side: Kallithea Springs

Kallithea Springs (Thermes Kallitheas)

An optional track, for a taxi, and for the birthday. Ask at the rank by the port for Kallithea Springs, Thermes Kallitheas. It is about fifteen minutes and fifteen to twenty euros south along the east coast. Agree the fare first. Open until eight, five euros to enter, and bring swim shoes, because the entry to the water is rock.

For centuries, reddish water surged out of a rock formation in this cove, and the locals of the Ottoman era called it Tsilonero and swore by it for arthritis, skin and asthma. In nineteen twenty-seven the Italian governor commissioned a scientific study, and in nineteen twenty-eight he handed the site to an architect named Pietro Lombardi, with Armando Bernabiti on decoration. What they built was inaugurated on the first of July nineteen twenty-nine. It was Art Deco with Moorish teeth. It has a small rotunda, fourteen metres across, with six gates in the Moorish style around a statue of Eros, built directly over the spring, with six fountains feeding a central pool. A larger rotunda has a curved arcade of benches that looks over the bay, its dome carried on two half-domes. Every path is paved in black-and-white pebble mosaics of plants and geometry, and the outer walls are painted with sea creatures. In the nineteen thirties it hosted an international congress of hydrologists and a jet-set clientele.

Then the war. The Germans turned the complex into a penitentiary; barbed wire and minefields had transformed the once impressive spa into a place of dismay, says the site's own history. It reopened in fits on Marshall Aid money and closed for good in nineteen sixty-seven. Hollywood found the ruin first. The Guns of Navarone, nineteen sixty-one, with Peck, Niven and Quinn, was shot here; so was Escape to Athena in nineteen seventy-nine. The municipality restored it between nineteen ninety-nine and two thousand and seven and reopened it with Anthony Quinn's family present. The spring itself has dried. This is a swimming cove now, with pergolas, a cafe-bar at the water, and sunbeds.

If you play games, you already have it: an abandoned temple to a healing god at the water's edge, mosaic wards underfoot, a dry sacred spring

under a rotunda shrine to Eros, and a wartime prison chapter for a haunted second act.

Swim. Have the drink. Give yourself an hour and a half, and be in the taxi by a quarter to five.

22 • B-side: The Hill of the Sun

Summit of Monte Smith (Kebrić's site) and the nymphaea

An optional track, for the acropolis of ancient Rhodes. Thirty-five minutes uphill from the Gate of Saint Athanasios at the south-west corner of the walls, or a ten-minute taxi from the rank by the port. Free, open-air, always open. It only fits the day if you give up the Palace interior or Mandraki, so it is here for the version of you that comes back.

The hill is called Monte Smith, after Admiral Sir Sidney Smith, the man who stopped Napoleon at Acre, who by local tradition set up an observation post here in eighteen oh two to watch for the French fleet. Every empire since the founding has posted lookouts on this ridge, because from here you can see the whole town, both harbours, the west coast, and the mountains of Turkey.

On the summit stand four Doric columns and a scrap of architrave, re-erected by the Italians and labelled since their excavations as the Temple of Pythian Apollo; in twenty twenty-five visitors found them fenced and scaffolded, so treat them as a silhouette for now. Below is the Hellenistic stadium, two hundred and ten metres long, with its curved end, its officials' seats, and the athletes' starting mechanism still in place; joggers use the track today. Beside it sits a little marble odeon for eight hundred, almost all reconstruction. And cut into the ridge between the temples are four nymphaea, cave sanctuaries with cisterns and niches. They were shrines to the water nymphs, and they are the closest thing on the hill to a real dungeon.

This is why the Colossus question comes up on this hill. Ursula Vedder, a German archaeologist, argued in twenty fifteen that a votive statue of Helios belongs in Helios's own precinct. She re-identified this big temple as the long-lost sanctuary of the sun, and read the ruin just north-east of it as the base and the workshop where the statue was cast, in large sections in pits nearby, rather than in the rising mound of earth that the ancient account describes. Robert Kebrić accepted her identification but pushed the statue higher, to the limestone shelf at the very top of the hill, beside the temple of Athena and Zeus where the city kept its treaties, so

that it could act as a beacon for all five harbours. His point about this hill is that only from here can you watch the sun's whole arc across the sea from rising to setting, which is why a city that worshipped the sun would put its sacred heart up here. Nathan Badoud, in twenty twenty-four, disagreed and put the sanctuary on the small hill under the Palace. Nobody has excavated to test any of it.

Walk the length of the stadium for scale. The statue was about a sixth of its length, lying down. Stand at the temple's north-east corner and look down over the stadium and the odeon to the harbours; that is the sightline Vedder argues the statue commanded.

And two Romans, to finish. Around seventy-five BC a young Julius Caesar sailed for Rhodes to study rhetoric with Apollonius Molon. On the way he was captured by pirates, and when they asked only twenty talents in ransom he laughed at them and offered fifty instead. He read them his poems for thirty-eight days and called them illiterate barbarians to their faces, then, once his ransom came through, he came back, caught them at anchor, and crucified them, having their throats cut first as a kindness. Cicero had studied here two years earlier and came home, he said, almost transformed. And in six BC the emperor's heir Tiberius walked away from Rome and spent eight years on this island in a modest house, going to the gymnasium without his lictors and arguing with the professors. He kept an astrologer named Thrasyllus. One day, on a cliff walk, convinced the man was a fraud, he resolved to push him off, and at that moment Thrasyllus pointed at a ship in the distance and said it carried good news. It was the recall to Rome. Sunset from this ridge is the famous slot. You will be at sea for it, which is its own kind of answer.